



Defensible space

Work outward from the house, only to your property line if closer. Maintain the space as leaves fall and plants grow.

Start with the first five feet. Reduce material that can ignite beside the house and under decks. Defensible space and home hardening work together; neither makes a home fireproof.

ZONE 0: 0 TO 5 FEET

- ☐ Replace combustible mulch beside the home with gravel, pavers or another noncombustible surface.
- ☐ Clear dead leaves, needles, weeds and debris, including roofs, gutters and under decks.
- ☐ Move firewood, lumber, bins and other combustible storage away from the house.
- ☐ Use noncombustible fencing or gates where they connect to the home.
- ☐ Review plants, furniture, vehicles and other combustibles close to walls and decks with your fire district.

ZONE 1: 5 TO 30 FEET

- ☐ Remove dead plants, grass and weeds; prune plants away from windows.
- ☐ Keep branches at least 10 feet from chimneys and stovepipes.
- ☐ Maintain separation between tree canopies and other vegetation. Slope, plant size and local rules affect the spacing needed.
- ☐ Clear combustible storage and vegetation under decks, balconies and stairs.

ZONE 2: 30 TO 100 FEET, OR THE PROPERTY LINE

- ☐ Keep annual grass no taller than four inches.
- ☐ Separate shrubs and trees horizontally, with more space on slopes; remove ladder fuels between low plants and tree branches.
- ☐ Remove excess fallen leaves, needles, twigs and small branches. CAL FIRE allows a layer up to three inches deep in this zone.
- ☐ Keep exposed woodpiles at least 10 feet clear of vegetation, down to mineral soil.

OFFICIAL SOURCES

[CAL FIRE: defensible space and spacing diagrams](#)



Harden the home

Prioritize the roof, vents and places where embers can collect or enter.

- ☐ **Roof:** remove debris and ask about a Class A fire-rated roof when replacing it.
- ☐ **Vents:** use ember- and flame-resistant vents where required. CAL FIRE describes 1/16- to 1/8-inch metal mesh for suitable openings; don't cover vents in ways that block required airflow.
- ☐ **Chimney:** use a noncombustible metal screen with openings from 3/8 to 1/2 inch.
- ☐ **Windows:** consider dual-pane windows with at least one tempered-glass pane.
- ☐ **Gutters, eaves and soffits:** clear debris and use suitable noncombustible or ignition-resistant materials.
- ☐ **Decks and siding:** use compliant materials and keep combustible items away from vulnerable spaces.
- ☐ **Garage:** weather-strip gaps and learn how to open the door without electricity.
- ☐ **Address and access:** keep your address visible from the road. Ask the fire district about your driveway's clearance and emergency-access requirements.

CHECK PROPERTY-SPECIFIC REQUIREMENTS

State and local requirements depend on the property. Zone 0 rules and compliance timing are changing; check current Board of Forestry guidance and confirm with your fire district. Ask separately about propane tanks, outbuildings, steep slopes, tree work and access. Stay within your property unless you have permission.

Boulder Creek Fire Protection District: 831-338-7222. Use the office for prevention questions. In an emergency, call 911.

PLAN THE WORK

Hire qualified professionals for hazardous tree work and roof access. Avoid spark-producing work in hot, dry or windy conditions. Check the Resource Conservation District's current chipping dates, availability and pile rules before cutting or stacking for pickup.

OFFICIAL SOURCES

[CAL FIRE: home-hardening guidance](#)

[Board of Forestry: Zone 0](#)

[Santa Cruz County RCD: chipping programs](#)